

At the beginning of our two hours, when it's relatively hot outside, it is natural for us to be open to creative exploration. Since we have a long time remaining, it's not a big risk to travel downward a little in order to understand the terrain better and see some new places. But as it gets cooler and we near the end of our two hours, we'll be less open to broad exploration. We'll be more narrowly focused on improvements and less willing to travel downward.

Take a moment to think about this strategy and why it's the best way to get to the highest point. We already talked about why we want to go down occasionally: so that we can avoid a "local optimum," or the top of a foothill next to a huge mountain. But when should we go down? Consider the last 10 seconds of our two-hour time period. No matter where we are, we should go as directly upward as we can at that time. It's no use to go down to explore new foothills and find new mountains during our last 10 seconds, since even if we found a promising mountain, we wouldn't have time to climb it, and if we make a mistake and slip downward during our last 10 seconds, we won't have time to correct it. Thus, the last 10 seconds is when we should go directly up and not consider going down at all.

By contrast, consider the first 10 seconds of our two-hour time period. During that time, there's no need to rush directly upward. At the beginning, we can learn the most from going a little downward to explore. If we make a mistake in the first 10 seconds, there's plenty of time to correct it later. We'll have plenty of time to take advantage of anything we learn or any mountains we find. During the first 10 seconds, it pays to be the most open about going down and the least zealous about going directly up.

You can understand the remainder of the two hours by thinking of the same ideas. If we consider the time 10 minutes before the end, we'll have a more moderate version of the mindset we had 10 seconds before the end. Since the end is near, we'll be motivated to go directly upward. However, 10 minutes is longer than 10 seconds, so we have some small amount of openness to a little bit of downward exploration just in case we discover something promising. By the same token, the time 10 minutes after the beginning will lead us to a more moderate version of the mindset we had 10 seconds after the beginning. The full two-hour time period will have a gradient of intention: a willingness to sometimes go down at first, followed by a gradually strengthening zeal to go only up.